Teach Us to Pray

Prayer is not a performance for others or a speech to inform God, but a child talking honestly with a Father who already knows and cares.

Main passage	Matthew 6:5-15 (KJV)
Topic	Prayer
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Pray to your Father, not to an audience	7 min
Teaching point 2: Pray simply, trusting a Father who knows	7 min
Teaching point 3: Pray the pattern Jesus gave: God first, then our needs	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "When you were a child, how did you learn to pray? Who taught you, and what did they teach you to say?" Let several people share. Then point out that even the disciples, who had prayed all their lives, asked Jesus, "Lord, teach us to pray" (Luke 11:1). Today Jesus teaches us how.

Teacher note: Some class members may feel awkward praying aloud. Reassure the class that nobody will be asked to pray aloud today unless they volunteer.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 6:5-15

[5] And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are: for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men. Verily I say unto you, They have

their reward. [6] But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly. [7] But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking. [8] Be not ye therefore like unto them: for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him. [9] After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. [10] Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. [11] Give us this day our daily bread. [12] And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. [13] And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen. [14] For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: [15] But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

Read the passage aloud. Invite the class to say the Lord's Prayer (verses 9-13) together when the reader reaches it.

Background (5 min)

These verses sit in the middle of the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5-7). In chapter 6 Jesus takes three practices every devout Jew of his day took seriously: giving to the poor, prayer, and fasting. For each one he warns against doing it "to be seen of men" and teaches doing it for the Father "which seeth in secret."

Barnes explains that the "closet" (v. 6) was a private room. Many Jewish houses had a small upper room where a person could pray alone. The "vain repetitions" of the heathen (v. 7) were long prayers that piled up names and phrases, as though the gods had to be worn down or reminded. Jesus' own prayer, which we call the Lord's Prayer, is striking for how short and simple it is.

Teaching point 1: Pray to your Father, not to an audience (7 min)

The hypocrites prayed on street corners so that people would admire them. They got what they wanted, the admiration, and that was all they got. Jesus calls us into a private room with the door shut. Public prayer is not wrong, since Jesus prayed in public too. The question is who we are really talking to.

Supporting verses

Matthew 6:5-6: And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are: for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward. But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

Mark 1:35: And in the morning, rising up a great while before day, he went out, and departed into a solitary place, and there prayed.

Psalm 62:8: Trust in him at all times; ye people, pour out your heart before him: God is a refuge for us. Selah.

> *"Prayer is the most secret intercourse of the soul with God, and as it were the conversation of one heart with another."*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 6:6

Handout blanks (answers)

The hypocrites prayed to be **seen** of men.

Jesus says to pray to your **Father** which is in secret.

Teaching point 2: Pray simply, trusting a Father who knows (7 min)

We do not pray to give God information. "Your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him" (v. 8). That does not make prayer pointless. It frees us from trying to impress God with many words. Prayer changes us. It humbles us, reminds us that we depend on him, and lifts our hearts toward him.

Supporting verses

Matthew 6:7-8: But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking. Be not ye therefore like unto them: for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him.

Luke 11:11-13: If a son shall ask bread of any of you that is a father, will he give him a stone? or if he ask a fish, will he for a fish give him a serpent? Or if he shall ask an egg, will he offer him a scorpion? If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children: how much more shall your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask him?

Philippians 4:6-7: Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.

> *“Prayer is not designed to inform God, but to give man a sight of his misery; to humble his heart, to excite his desire, to inflame his faith, to animate his hope, to raise his soul from earth to heaven”*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 6:8

> *“We shall come with hope and familiar confidence, for 'your heavenly Father knoweth what things ye have need of.'”*
> — Alexander Maclaren, Expositions of Holy Scripture, on Matthew 6:9

Handout blanks (answers)

God does not need many words, because he already **knows** what we need.

Prayer is not to inform God but to change our **hearts**.

Teaching point 3: Pray the pattern Jesus gave: God first, then our needs (7 min)

The Lord's Prayer begins with God: his name, his kingdom, his will. Only then does it turn to us: daily bread, forgiveness, and protection from temptation. That order is a good school for all our praying. Notice too that it says "our" and "us" all the way through. Even alone in the closet, we pray as members of God's family.

Supporting verses

Matthew 6:9-13 (read from the Bible)

Luke 11:1-4: And it came to pass, that, as he was praying in a certain place, when he ceased, one of his disciples said unto him, Lord, teach us to pray, as John also taught his disciples. And he said unto them, When ye pray, say, Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth. Give us day by day our daily bread. And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us. And lead us not into temptation; but deliver us from evil.

1 John 5:14: And this is the confidence that we have in him, that, if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us:

> *"This passage contains the Lord's prayer, a composition unequalled for comprehensiveness and for beauty."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 6:9

> *"This petition implies our dependence on God for the supply of our wants."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 6:11

Handout blanks (answers)

The Lord's Prayer begins with God's name, kingdom, and **will**.

Asking for daily bread reminds us that we **depend** on God every day.

Teacher note: Verses 14-15 return to forgiveness. If the class wants more on this, see the Forgiveness lesson on Matthew 18.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why is praying "to be seen" so tempting, even in church?

We care what people think of us; public prayer can quietly become a way to look spiritual. The cure is to remember who we are speaking to.

2. If God already knows what we need, why pray at all?

Prayer is relationship, not information. It expresses trust, humbles us, aligns our desires with God's, and God has chosen to work through his children's prayers.

3. Which part of the Lord's Prayer do you find easiest to pray, and which hardest?

Answers will vary. Many find "thy will be done" or "forgive us … as we forgive" hardest.

4. How could the order of the Lord's Prayer (God first, then our needs) change your own prayers this week?

Beginning with praise and God's purposes puts our requests in perspective and guards against treating God as a vending machine.

Application (3 min)

Choose a "closet" this week: a quiet place and a set time, even five minutes. Shut the door, and pray the Lord's Prayer slowly, one line at a time. After each line, add your own words about what that line means for you today.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Our Father in heaven, thank you that we may come to you as children. Teach us to pray, not to be seen or to impress, but to talk honestly with you. Hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come, your will be done in our lives. Give us today what we need, forgive us as we forgive, and keep us from evil. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 6:6

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 6:8

Alexander Maclaren, Expositions of Holy Scripture, on Matthew 6:9

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 6:9

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Matthew 6:11

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